

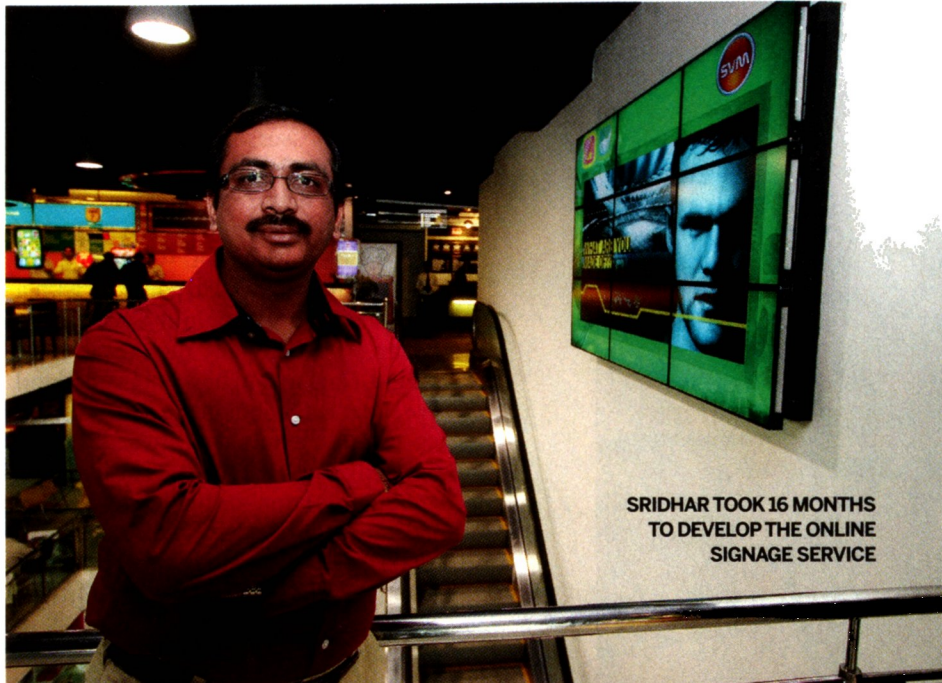


**MASTERMIND
INDIA**
Spirit of India Special

THE AD EFFECT

A failed experiment on connecting two computers to create a local area network while in Class VIII turned out to be a calling for greater challenges for Kusumba Sridhar. Result? Kiosk Mint, the world's first online digital signage platform which does to digital signage screens in public places what Google has done to online advertising. "The thought of developing this came from the offline digital signage medium that makes the advertiser shy away as it doesn't provide any statistics of the impressions nor gives the advertiser control over his campaign," says its creator Sridhar, 33, who spent four years until 1995 in the merchant navy. In 2000, he floated his own company, an Internet telephony service provider called Vebtel Obconic Internet Protocol.

It took Sridhar 16 months to develop the product that cost Rs 1.6 crore and he funded it wholly on his own. He is upbeat about recovering the cost and even laughing his way to the bank. Efficacy is its advantage. Offline digital signage is blind to the advertiser who is eager to get proof of performance of his campaign and auditable statistics for the money he spends on it. With Kiosk Mint all it takes is to go to its website, register and then post the campaign by selecting kiosks on the network. The campaign begins in less than 30 minutes. The advertiser is billed for



SRIDHAR TOOK 16 MONTHS
TO DEVELOP THE ONLINE
SIGNAGE SERVICE

Kusumba SRIDHAR, 33

INNOVATION

**Online digital
signage service**

COST OF PRODUCTION

Rs 1.6 crore

WHAT IT DOES

**Helps advertisers post
a campaign online with
the facility of making
real-time changes**

**IN THE WORKS ARE
VERSIONS TO DELIVER
CONTENT OVER
BLUETOOTH FROM
KIOSKS AND
BLUETOOTH-BASED
GAMING ON KIOSKS.**

each impression that happens on the kiosk. Just as the advertiser is debited with the impression cost, the premises owner is credited with his share.

For this, Kiosk Mint has adopted a conventional computer of standard configuration that can be used as the media player with the client software loaded in it. Each kiosk costs Rs 32,000 to Rs 65,000, depending on the size of the screen. Large mosaic kiosks cost between Rs. 3.5 lakh and Rs 8 lakh. "We have signed with 10 top locations in Hyderabad and are currently completing the installation, including a 103-inch LCD. We have installed it on the Aero Express buses that ply from the heart of Hyderabad to the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport," says Sridhar. Additional features and functions can be included with appropriate software updates.

Earlier, he designed a flight simulator for the Cessna-172 Garmin-1000 model indigenously, at almost half the cost of an imported one, and sold it to the Chimes Aviation Academy, Dhana, Madhya Pradesh. As if all this wasn't enough, Sridhar now plans to build a plane. Flying high seems to be his mantra for success.

by Amarnath K. Menon